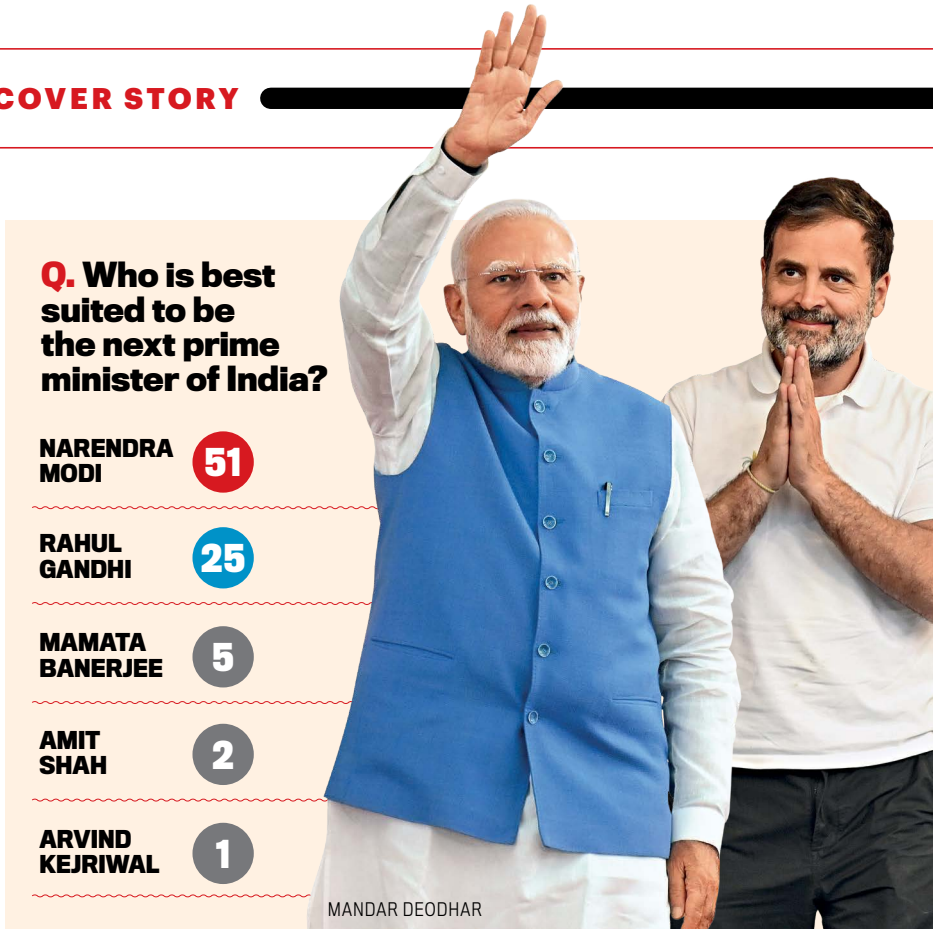
general election was held now, the BJP would secure a majority on its own, with its tally projection growing to 281 seats. That is nine more than the simple majority of 272 and a 41-seat jump from its actual tally in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. As a result, the NDA's total seats also go up from 293 to 343—a truly comfortable majority.

Modi's performance ratings, too, have shot up in the past six months. The current MOTN reveals that 61.8 per cent of those surveyed rate his performance as either good or outstanding, compared to 58.6 per cent in August 2024. Though Modi had the highest ever rating of 78 per cent in August 2020, that too in the thick of the first wave of the Covid pandemic, getting a ringing endorsement higher than 60 per cent after being in the saddle for over 10 years can only be seen as phenomenal. Since the India Today MOTN surveys kicked off in 2003, no other Indian prime minister has sustained such high popularity ratings. By the third year of his second term as PM, Manmohan Singh's personal popularity had plunged to a nadir from which it never recovered.

Even on the question of who is best suited to be the next prime minister, 51.2 per cent, or a majority, of those surveyed want Modi to continue. The prime minister maintains a massive lead of 26 percentage points over his nearest rival, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi. Rahul's ratings have gone up by two percentage points to 24.9 per cent—largely, it seems, on the back of being Leader of the Opposition. The survey also showed that a majority (50.7 per cent) regard Modi as India's best prime minister, with Manmohan Singh coming a distant second with 13.6 per cent. The performance rating of the NDA government is also indicative of how the alliance has gained significantly after the Lok Sabha polls. Over 62 per cent of the respondents said they were either satisfied or very satisfied with the overall performance of the NDA government, up four percentage points from the August 2024 MOTN.



DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say; all figures in % and rounded off

Modi retains a massive 26 percentage point lead over Rahul Gandhi. If earlier the perception was that the BJP could not do without Modi, now it seems the NDA would not be stable without him

LESSONS LEARNED WELL

The big message of the February 2025 MOTN, therefore, is that Modi and the BJP are truly back with a bang. They seem to have achieved this by learning the lessons from the general election, especially shedding the overconfidence and arrogance they exhibited. Just before the campaign, BJP president J.P. Nadda had proclaimed that the party had grown up and was no longer in need of its ideological mentor, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), to win electoral support. That tune changed shortly after, so much so that the BJP worked synergistically with the RSS for all the three assembly polls, taking their help not just to mobilise the cadres but also systematically approach voters and win them over.

Meanwhile, even Modi did a U-turn on his distaste for what he has earlier dismissed as the *revdi* or freebie culture of the Opposition. The NDA announced massive cash doles for women in Maharashtra, and matched or even exceeded the goodies the Aam Aadmi Party offered in Delhi. For the campaigns in these three elections, rather than the blitzkrieg approach of the Lok Sabha polls, Modi held strategic rallies and left saturation campaigning on the ground to local leaders and organisational workers from other states.

On the governance front, PM Modi pivoted to the compulsions of coalition politics, meeting most of the key demands of his two allies—the Janata Dal (United) or JD(U) in Bihar and the Telugu Desam Party in Andhra Pradesh—giving them the financial allocations they wanted. That generosity did not